This multicultural milieu set the stage for the next phase of evolution of India's civilization. Over the next century, Calcutta would attract social reformers like Ram Mohun Roy, who pushed through important changes that have shaped modern India. Interestingly, these early reformers also argued in favour of providing education to Indians in the English language. This would be a profoundly important choice.

It is popularly assumed that English education was used by the colonial rulers to create a class of Indians who would be loyal to them. This view is based a note written by Thomas Macaulay in 1835 where he argued, 'We must at present do our best to form a class who may be interpreters between us and the millions whom we govern; a class of persons, Indian in blood and colour, but English in taste, in opinions, in morals, and in intellect'. In fact, the matter was hotly debated by the British officials and there were many who disagreed with Macaulay. The factor that tipped the balance was that many reformist Indians favoured English. This preference for a foreign language is not as strange as it may appear at first sight. The early reformers were very conscious that Indian civilization had been in decline for a long time and correctly blamed it on lack of technological and intellectual innovation. The knowledge of English was seen as a window to the world of ideas emanating from Europe. Far from creating a class of loyal Indians, the English-educated middle-class would be at the forefront of India's struggle for independence.

One of the important venues for the Anglo-Indian intellectual interaction of this era was a unique college founded in 1800 by Governor General Wellesley. The College of Fort William was set up for the training of British civil servants who spent their first three years studying and training there. The curriculum for the three-year course was surprisingly eclectic and tells of a generalist ethos that remains embedded in the Indian Administrative Service of today: [2]

1. Choice of Languages: Arabic, Persian, Sanskrit, Marhatta (Marathi), Tamalua (Tamil), Bengali, Telenga (Telugu).
2. Mahomedan Law
3. Hindoo Law